Think Pair Share

Preparing everyone to answer

Use Think–Pair–Share when students need independent thinking and private rehearsal before a public response. Protect the Think stage so the quickest speaker does not supply everyone's first idea.

How to do it well

1 Design a thinking-worthy prompt. Ask pupils to retrieve, connect, compare, justify or explain; keep the prompt visible as an anchor.

2 Protect THINK. Give uninterrupted silent time for each pupil to retrieve and, when useful, jot keywords, evidence or a first decision.

3 Structure PAIR. Specify who speaks first, what the listener must do, when roles swap and what the pair must improve or agree.

4 Run an inclusive SHARE. Cold call pairs or individuals so either partner may summarise, justify or report the other person's idea; probe contrasting reasoning.

5 Adapt the sequence. Use Think–Write–Pair–Share, partner-summary writing, mini-whiteboards or a batched share when these strengthen retrieval or accountability.

What this sounds like

"Think alone and write one reason. Partner A explains first; Partner B checks the evidence. Swap, then be ready to share your partner's strongest point."

Classroom example. In Geography, pupils individually choose the most important cause and write a reason. Partners compare evidence with clear speaking roles, then pupils share a partner's strongest point. A final individual explanation captures the refined thinking. The initial silent stage prevents one confident partner supplying both pupils' starting ideas.

Top tips that make the technique work

Make thinking silent. Ask for a mental answer or short jot before anyone turns to a partner.

Choose a worthwhile prompt. Explanation, comparison and justification give partners something to develop.

Specify the first speaker. A simple A/B or seating rule prevents negotiation and domination.

Give the listener a task. Restate, question or identify the strongest reason rather than wait for a turn.

Share through accountable sampling. Cold call or collect a fresh individual response; do not assume hearing lively talk means everyone understood.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Keep all three stages distinct.	Starting the conversation before individual thinking.
Require both partners to contribute.	Allowing the Share stage to return to volunteers only.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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